

Class X CBSE exams are out, but what's in?

WHAT'S DONE

CBSE will scrap the Class X board exam for plus two schools probably from next year.

CBSE will replace it with an online and offline on-demand test for children who are to be transferred after Class X.

The HRD Ministry is working on a core common maths and science curriculum.

CBSE has only now begun discussion on a common entrance exam for all colleges.

The HRD Ministry has not done enough to broaden vocational education in India.

WHAT REMAINS TO BE DONE

It is yet to work out details of the continuous evaluation system that will replace it.

The absence of marks will make the choosing of plus two streams a contentious issue in most schools.

But it has to ensure its acceptance by all state boards.

How will it handle the logistical nightmare of such an examination for all universities?

The basic problem is that the demand for college seats outstrips supply.

between two stools.

Over the years, the CBSE exam has been reduced to a formula, allowing neither autonomy of teachers nor the understanding of students. Academic Kiran Datar, who was on the advisory board of CBSE for five years, says one of the issues plaguing it is the wide diversity in school standards, which makes it a victim of such reductionism. It has reduced the Class X and Class XII exams to the lowest common denominator, making it increasingly objective, discouraging the students' creativity and originality. "Examination reform has to be accompanied by teacher training. A continuous evaluation of students requires a continuous empowerment of teachers," she says. Some part of it has been achieved with the reinvented NCERT textbooks and the formulation of a progressive National Curriculum Framework (NCF) in 2005. But change has to be simultaneous oth-

erwise it will be much like the way the previous HRD minister interpreted the National Knowledge Commission's recommendation to create more universities—by establishing 15 more at one stroke of the pen without the necessary infrastructure.

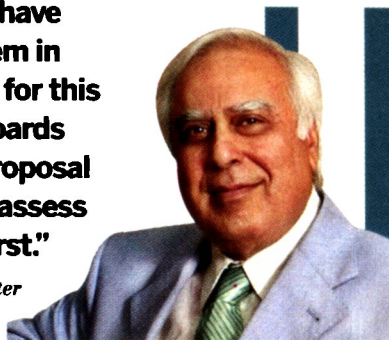


"The examination system has to be delinked from the certification system. Delhi University can set the tone by having a common entrance exam for its 80-odd colleges."

R. GOVINDA, acting vice-chancellor,
NUEPA

"We are going to have the grading system in CBSE for Class X for this year. The state boards appreciate our proposal but they want to assess our experience first."

KAPIL SIBAL, HRD Minister



The basic problem remains not that the absence of an examination will remove the incentive for teachers to teach and students to study, but one of demand and supply. Even with only 10 per cent of all school students going up to higher education, there is a shortage of quality institutions. As Manipur Minister for School Education Lal Sawta said at the Central Advisory Board of Education meeting, most students who pass out of Class XII do not get jobs. Vocational education is still not developed. As Arun Kapur, director, Vasant Valley, Delhi, puts it, the whole purpose of the Class X exam was to assist the streaming of children into vocational and non-vocational tracks. "But the vocational part was never seriously implemented," he says.

But the HRD Ministry is clearly in high speed mode, as was evidenced by the passing of the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act and the government then realising it is short by Rs 60,000 crore which it wants state governments to provide. Instead of piecemeal change, what is needed is a systemic and simultaneous transformation, perhaps led by the NCERT, CBSE and Delhi University. "The NCERT has already a very good NCF in place, the CBSE is in the process of rethinking exams, now Delhi University has to show the way and formulate a central admission exam for its 80-odd colleges," says Govinda. Indeed, all universities will have to develop their own admission system where the school-leaving examination is only one ingredient in a student's application.

Few academics doubt the efficacy of removing an exam that was a hangover from an era where Class X signified the end of school. It would have meant retaining a fossil, says Eklavya's Vinod Raina, especially with failure rates in some states going up to 50 per cent. But it would be more sensible to reform in one shot rather than in small doses. ■